



Windy, cooler 45/29 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 46/31 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

THURSDAY, DECEMBER 12, 2024 • \$3

Fire scorches through Malibu but could be abating



MARIO TAMA/GETTY IMAGES

Los Angeles County firefighters work to put out hotspots Wednesday at a destroyed home in Malibu, California. The wildfire, fueled by strong Santa Ana winds and low humidity, has grown to 4,000 acres and razed some homes, forcing thousands, including actor Dick Van Dyke and singer Cher, to evacuate. **Story, A3**

Syrian rebels now face the hard part: Governing

BY LOVEDAY MORRIS AND ABBIE CHEESEMAN

DAMASCUS, SYRIA — After sweeping into this capital city with ease, exposing the hollowness of the Assad regime after more than half a century of dictatorial rule, Syria’s rebels now face the more daunting task of governance. As forces from Hayat Tahrir al-Sham, the Islamist group that led the charge, advanced steadily from their home base in the north to the gates of the presidential palace, they released conciliatory

Group must show fearful public that it doesn’t seek absolute rule like Assad

messages on social media reassuring minorities they would not be persecuted and emphasizing a commitment to a Syria for all Syrians. Now in charge of a newly hopeful but still wary nation, HTS is confronted with vexing challenges. The group will need to consoli-

date control over a patchwork of rebel forces and demonstrate political inclusivity, which will be key to getting relief from international sanctions. Most critically, the rebels must allay public fears that they will seek to replace Assadism with their own form of absolute rule. For now, the group’s political plan revolves around exporting its government from Idlib — the northern province where it built up organizational power in recent years — to Damascus. It is too soon to tell how HTS’s model of local administration will trans-

late on a national scale, as it expands its area of control from a small, conservative Sunni Muslim enclave to a vast swath of territory home to many sects and ethnicities. Even in Damascus, the newcomers are still mostly unknown. At a store selling freshly printed Syrian revolutionary flags on Wednesday, shopkeeper Fadi al-Mously couldn’t name the country’s new prime minister, **SEE SYRIA ON A13** **West Bank:** Trump’s election win is emboldening Israeli settlers. **A8**

Musk has transformed from a climate crusader to a critic

BY PRANSHU VERMA, ELIZABETH DWOSKIN, FAIZ SIDDIQUI AND SHANNON OSAKA

Earlier this year, top executives at Tesla gathered in Palo Alto to sell CEO Elon Musk on a line of compact cars that would bring the electric-vehicle revolution to budget-conscious consumers across the world. The more affordable car had long been part of Musk’s master plan for Tesla to fight climate change by “accelerat[ing] the world’s transition to sustainable energy.” But Musk axed the proposal,

amid budget constraints, according to two people close to Musk who spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe private conversations. Instead, the billionaire green-lit a massive purchase of computer chips, in a deal worth billions intended to enhance Tesla’s luxury cars (and a humanoid robot called Optimus) with energy-intensive artificial intelligence capabilities. The internal deliberations over the so-called Tesla Model 2, which **SEE MUSK ON A2** **Green-mobile:** Small SUVs now are the nation’s cleanest cars. **A20**

Murder suspect’s severe pain shaped view of health system

BY DANIEL GILBERT, OLIVIA GEORGE AND ANNIE GOWEN

Even when Luigi Mangione was surrounded with people who cared about him, he was isolated by a spinal defect that gave the athletic young man crippling pain and contributed to a jaundiced view of the American health-care system. Authorities charged Mangione, 26, with murder in the shooting of

UnitedHealthcare CEO Brian Thompson in New York, and New York police said Wednesday that they believe the motive was animus toward the health insurance industry and corporate America. Police found a three-page handwritten document on Mangione that expressed disdain for the health business, they have said. **SEE SUSPECT ON A16** **Forensic match:** Bullet casings at scene linked to suspect’s gun. **A16**

Young go-kart drivers and their families endure intense competition and big expenses for a shot at the world’s most exclusive starting grid



PHOTOS BY CLAUDIA GORI FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

THE FIRST STEP TO F1

BY KEVIN SIEFF, CLAUDIA GORI AND ZOEANN MURPHY IN SARNO, ITALY

Julian and Alessandro were walking to the starting line, trying their best not to look at each other. They wore child-size racing uniforms and tiny driving gloves. Behind them, mechanics pushed their 160-pound cars with a list of corporate sponsors on the hood. The team’s name was emblazoned on the side: Baby Race. The two boys were Baby Race’s star drivers, among the

Alessandro Truchot, left, and Julian Frasnelli are recognized as Baby Race’s two top drivers. Despite racing for the same team, their rivalry has sometimes resulted in crashes, and their families do not speak to each other.

favorites to win the World Series of Karting championship that was minutes away. In theory, they could work together to secure a team victory. But Alessandro Truchot and Julian Frasnelli had been fierce competitors since they were 9 and 10. Now they were 11 and 12, respectively, and the rivalry had grown violent, culminating in high-speed crashes that caused a roaring crowd **SEE RACING ON A10**

Wray to resign before Trump takes office

EXIT FORESHADOWS BID TO RESHAPE FBI

President-elect, loyalist Patel point to era of reprisal

BY PERRY STEIN

FBI Director Christopher A. Wray announced Wednesday that he would resign at the end of the Biden administration, stepping down as the leader of the powerful law enforcement bureau before President-elect Donald Trump takes office and can fire him. Wray’s resignation comes seven years into his 10-year term — a tenure that is meant to span multiple administrations and is intentionally longer than other executive branch appointments to avoid politicization of the FBI. Trump announced last month that he would nominate loyalist Kash Patel to serve as FBI director, sending a message to Wray that he should either resign or prepare to be fired. Patel has echoed Trump’s calls for retribution against perceived enemies, and he has called for using federal law enforcement to prosecute both political opponents and journalists. His looming nomination, along with Wray’s decision to resign, underscores the reality that the Trump administration will attempt to obliterate long-standing norms at the FBI and dramatically reshape the bureau. Wray announced his plans at a town hall with the FBI workforce Wednesday afternoon, telling his employees that while it was a hard decision to cut his term short, he believed it was the best one for the bureau. It was an emotional meeting, according to an FBI official, and Wray’s announcement was met with a long-standing ovation from his staff. After the town hall, Wray



JABIN BOTSFORD/THE WASHINGTON POST

Christopher A. Wray, seven years into a 10-year term as FBI director, said he will resign at the Biden administration’s end.

shook hands with many of the FBI employees in the room. “My goal is to keep the focus on our mission — the indispensable work you’re doing on behalf of the American people every day. In my view, this is the best way to avoid dragging the Bureau deeper into the fray, while reinforcing the values and principles that are so important to how we do our work,” Wray said, according to excerpts released by the FBI. “It should go without saying, but I’ll say it anyway — this is not easy for me,” he continued. **SEE WRAY ON A6** **‘Actual fear’: Civil servants hurry to avoid becoming targets. A4** **Sergio Gor:** The publisher/DJ is shaping Trump’s government. **C1**

Tensions rise between Md. and D.C. over stadium deal

BY SAM FORTIER, ERIN COX AND MICHAEL BRICE-SADDLER

D.C. Mayor Muriel E. Bowser (D) on Wednesday said leaders in neighboring Maryland are holding up a deal that could pave the way for the Washington Commanders football team to build its next stadium at the RFK Stadium site. During an annual Federal City Council meeting, Bowser said Maryland is delaying an agreement over federal legislation that would give the District greater control of the RFK site by linking that deal to the state’s pursuit of its other priorities, including separate legislation promising that the federal government will fully fund efforts to rebuild the collapsed Francis Scott Key Bridge, estimated to cost as much as \$1.9 billion. “We’re being held hostage by Maryland,” Bowser told her colleagues at the group of business and civic leaders when asked about the status of the RFK legislation during a question-and-answer session at the meeting, according to three people who were in the room and spoke on the condition of anonymity to describe **SEE STADIUM ON A7**

IN THE NEWS

Culture war legislation The House passed a defense policy bill, but Democrats and some Republicans were frustrated by a provision on health care for transgender youth. **A6** **Beneath the Lincoln Memorial** Workers are carving out a multimillion-dollar visitor area with amenities focused on Lincoln’s legacy. **B1**

THE NATION **The Supreme Court** allowed a shareholder lawsuit against Nvidia to proceed. **A2** **NASA offered** more details on why the Mars helicopter Ingenuity crashed this year. **A3**

THE WORLD **An arrest** on insurrection allegations is being considered for South Korea’s president. **A9** **Ukraine is racing** to develop its own long-range weapons to counter Russia’s. **A12**

THE ECONOMY **The Nasdaq index** closed above 20,000 for the first time as Wall Street anticipated a cut in interest rates. **A15** **Progress** on combating inflation stalled in November, new data shows, underscoring Americans’ economic concerns. **A16**

THE REGION **Lawmakers grilled** Maryland’s health secretary about violence at the maximum-security Clifton T. Perkins Hospital Center. **B1** **Officials** in Warren County, Virginia, voted to exert control over a library that defended LGBTQ+ books. **B1**

SPORTS **Bill Belichick**, a six-time Super Bowl champion, will join the college ranks, reaching a deal to coach North Carolina. **D1** **LOCAL LIVING** **A little extra effort** when it comes to wrapping presents can make a gift — and the recipient — feel extra special.

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